



IN CONTEXT

Urban spirituality

Muism (Korean folk religion) was the dominant religious practice in the Korean peninsula until the arrival of Buddhism in the 4th century CE. During the 21st century, Muism has made a comeback—part mystical, part commercial—especially in the South Korean capital, Seoul. In this dynamic, industrial city, and across the nation, the rituals of Muist spiritual specialists are both semi-clandestine and widely acknowledged. Practitioners of Muism—*manshin*—are almost all women. For a fee, they advise on modern-day transactions such as which car or house to buy, or what job to apply for. To ask for the intervention of gods and ancestors, *manshin* perform *gut* rites that help them cross into the spirit world and find answers. Dressed in flamboyant clothes, they dance, sing, pray, and make offerings and sacrifices to the spirits on an altar purified by fire and water.

A *manshin* performs a purifying ritual with white paper.

While practices labeled shamanistic take different forms in different regions, the basic belief that a higher spiritual wisdom determines human fates is common to all. For example, the San people of southern Africa—until the 1950s among the last hunter-gatherers in the world—believe in an overarching spirit world. At the other end of the globe, shamans such as the *mide* of the Ojibwe in Canada and *angakoks* of the Inuit in the Arctic are revered as spiritual advisers of great knowledge, in touch with the powers that guide people's fates.

► Fetish medicine

This traditional healer in Lomé, Togo, recites incantations to help cure a patient who bows down in front of an array of fetishes, including skulls, statuettes, and feathers.



On an individual level, many people who are ill still consult shamans, healers, or medicine people because they trust in their power to cure them. In much of Latin America, for instance, traditional healers are known as *curanderos* (see p.283) and their healing practices may make use of trance, prayer, spiritual cleansing, herbs and oils, or hallucinogens such as *peyote*. Fetish healers are common in West Africa, where the fetish (talisman) market in Togo's capital Lomé is famous across the region, and people come to be treated for ailments ranging

from asthma to erectile dysfunction, typhoid to tuberculosis. Meanwhile, the people known in different Native American tribes variously as doctors, herbalists, curers, diagnosticians, or medicine people, are renowned for their healing powers as well as for being spiritual leaders.

In its original Siberian homelands, shamanism has reemerged. Suppressed under Soviet rule, it has resurfaced hesitantly since the early 1990s. Likewise, shamanism in Mongolia, which was banned